NETWORK INFILTRATION

↘ The contracted company instals proxy servers in the exam centre's local network, creating secret backdoors

↘ Remote-access tools loaded onto the computer systems, allowing off-site operatives full control during the exam

REAL-TIME DELIVERY

↘ The 'solver guild' tracks the test feed, solves questions remotely and relays answers instantly

↘ Pre-selected candidates receive these answers mid-test—via subtle on-screen prompts or whispered cues from co-opted invigilators

ON-GROUND COORDINATION

↘ Invigilators stay linked with solvers through encrypted apps or coded messages to confirm delivery. In case of any slips, they correct them on the fly

SEAMLESS ERASURE

↘ Post exam, all digital footprints vanish—servers shut down, access tools are wiped, logs cleared. The illusion of integrity is maintained

THE CLASSIC OFFLINE HEIST

THE PAPER-LEAK CHAIN THAT SANJEEV KUMAR MUKHIYA HAD BUILT OVER THE PAST DECADE



↘ **Gangs infiltrated** printing presses, strongrooms or logistics chain to access sealed exam papers

↘ **Leaked papers were solved** by hired experts, such as MBBS and engineering graduates

↘ **Answer keys were circulated** via coaching centres, WhatsApp groups or handed directly to candidates, who paid as much as Rs 10–40 lakh

According to an EOU officer, Bhushan originally supplied personnel to test centres in Patna, and later expanded operations to Mumbai and Delhi through a firm called Bramcize Technology Pvt Ltd. He and his brother Bharat even secured the contract for the AIIMS Mangalagiri recruitment exam—later postponed after the CHO leak was exposed.

CLOSING THE NET

The fallout has prompted sweeping action. The March 2024 TRE 3.0 conducted by the Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) was cancelled and rescheduled for July. Similarly, of the other five exams compromised since 2022, three were cancelled outright while two were partially scrapped. Crucially, the Bihar Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act was passed in July 2024—one of the most stringent in the country. Offenders now face up to five years in prison and fines up to Rs 10 lakh. Service providers involved in leaks can be blacklisted for four years and fined up to Rs 1 crore. Candidates caught buying leaked papers or 'cheat sheets' risk disqualification and ineligibility for government jobs. The BPSC website lists at least 22 such debarments, though many continue to contest them.

To prevent future breaches, the EOU has scaled up its surveillance machinery. Operational reforms include unbreakable seals for physical papers, mandatory CCTV surveillance at printing and dispatch sites, real-time monitoring for online tests and audits of logistics partners. "We have established a consolidated database of organised gangs involved in leaks and other irregularities, which we continuously monitor and share with the neighbouring states of Uttar Pradesh and Jharkhand as well as Odisha to coordinate our actions," says DIG Dhillon. "Ahead of every exam, we deploy both technical and physical surveillance, and we are now compiling a comprehensive register of all online testing centres in Bihar." After the CHO exam was breached via proxy servers, the EOU has also expanded efforts to monitor educational consultancies and social media groups.

But the real test lies ahead. For every arrest, dozens of small-time operatives remain at large. Convictions are rare, and the racket evolves faster than the rules. "To fortify examination integrity, authorities must adopt the Supreme Court's NEET-UG safeguards introduced last year," says Sanjeev Kumar, an advocate at the Patna High Court. "These include rigorous SOPs for question paper handling and storage, biometric authentication for invigilators and candidates, stringent centre allocation reviews, independent audits and a robust grievance redressal mechanism. Most importantly, breaches must be met with prompt prosecution—with interim suspension of officials under investigation."

Still, the arrests of Mukhiya and Bhushan have struck a nerve. For a state gearing up for election, it's not just a law-and-order issue but a moral one—whether the promise of merit can be restored in a system bent under the weight of exam breaches. Until Bihar moves from reactive clean-ups to preventive deterrence—through both justice and structural reform—every exam will remain suspect and every deserving candidate a potential victim of the next scam. ■